

the listener to be occupied by sonic images—and creates an artificial boomer bass effect. It's all intuitive, actually: imagine your ears surrounded and enclosed by cups (closed headphones), and imagine a “ventilated” situation (open headphones). The latter will, of course, sound more natural.

Sennheiser HD650/HD600

Sennheiser is one of the most respected names in headphones, and their headphones are amongst the world's best. The HD650 is their top-of-the-line model, and the HD600 is almost the same. These currently retail at \$400 (Rs 19,000) and \$300 (Rs 14,000) respectively.



The HD600 and HD650, in comparison to other open audio-ophile headphones, are somewhat partial to treble. When you listen to these—as also to the Grados we mention next—trust us, you'll hear sounds in your music that you never knew existed!

Grado RS-1

Grado is another very respected name in headphones, though not as well-known as Sennheiser. Audiophiles are a very vocal lot, and will speak endlessly of the virtues of the phones of their choice. There are many who believe the Grado RS-1 is the best pair of headphones out there, barring those used in professional recording studios, which cost thousands of dollars. The chassis of the RS1 is handcrafted from cured mahogany wood! The bass, in our opinion, is better than that on the high-end Sennheisers. A four-word summary of these phones would be “breathtaking realism and detail”—but read the numerous audiophile reviews on the Internet

